Decision Lab Handout

Winning Frame exercise for group breakout discussions

Use this handout to work through each scenario as a group. Your task is not to jump to the answer. Identify the frame you are using, test whether it fits the problem, and build a better frame before deciding what follows.

Core rule Do not decide what to do until you have written your winning frame.	**Group size** 6–7 leaders	**Scenarios** 2

How to work as a group

- Start with 2–3 plausible current frames. Then choose the one your group believes is dominant.
- Stress-test the dominant frame using **Decision**, **Boundaries**, and **Viewpoint**.
- Generate 2–3 stronger alternative frames before selecting a winning frame.
- Only after selecting the winning frame should you rewrite the decision question and discuss the action that follows.

Your output for each scenario

1. 2–3 current frames	**2.** 1 dominant frame
3. 2 reasons the dominant frame is incomplete or risky	**4.** 2–3 better frames
5. 1 winning frame	**6.** 1 rewritten decision question

Suggested roles and timing

Facilitator Keeps the group on framing	**Recorder** Captures outputs	**Challenger** Questions assumptions
Stakeholder voice Brings in missing perspectives	**Timekeeper** Keeps pace	**Spokesperson** Shares the final frame

Suggested time per scenario: **5 min** identify current frames, **7 min** stress-test, **8 min** build better frames, **5 min** prepare report-out.

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Using AI during the exercise

Use AI to augment the framing process, not to replace it. Use AI only after your group has first written its own current frame.

Mirror. [redacted]

Use AI as a mirror to make your current frame visible.

Prompt AI with:	Do not ask AI to:
• Help us identify the current frame we are using. • Describe the frame, list its embedded assumptions, explain what success we seem to be optimising for. • Show what this frame makes us focus on, and highlight what may be outside our awareness. • **Do not improve the frame yet.**	• Do not let AI choose the frame for you. • Do not ask for the final answer or the strategy recommendation yet.

Challenger. [redacted]

Use AI as a challenger to test whether your dominant frame fits the problem.

Prompt AI with:	Do not ask AI to:
• Evaluate whether our dominant frame still fits. • What assumptions are embedded in this frame? • What does it help us see, and what does it cause us to miss? • Where do the facts support or contradict it? • What else should we test before keeping this frame? • **Do not recommend a strategy yet.**	• Do not treat AI output as proof. • Use it to challenge your thinking, not to settle the debate or choose the action.

Reframing generator. [redacted]

Use AI as a reframing generator to generate stronger alternative frames after you have challenged the dominant one.

Prompt AI with:	Do not ask AI to:
• Help us build a better frame than our current one. • Generate 3 alternative frames for this decision. • For each one, explain what it assumes, what it highlights, what it risks underweighting, and what success would mean under that frame. • Suggest which 1-2 frames best fit the facts, without giving the final strategy recommendation.	• Do not ask AI to select the winning frame automatically. • Humans choose the frame they are willing to own and act on.

Helpful rule: Humans set the frame. AI stretches the frame. Humans choose the frame.

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3-step working method

Step A

Identify current frame(s)

- Write 2-3 possible current frames in one sentence each. Then choose the one your group thinks is dominant.
- What is this decision about?
- What kind of problem is this?
- What does success look like?
- What current frames are plausible?
- Which one is dominant?

Step B

Stress-test the dominant frame

- Test whether your dominant frame fits using Decision, Boundaries, and Viewpoint.
- Is this the right decision question?
- What is in or out of scope?
- From whose perspective are we judging success?
- Are we solving the right problem?
- What have we left out that should matter?
- Whose perspective is missing?

Step C

Find or build a better frame

- Generate 2-3 better frames. Then select one winning frame and rewrite the decision under that frame.
- What frame would lead to a better decision?
- A better frame for this decision is…
- Under this frame, the real decision becomes…
- The most important trade-off becomes…
- Generate 2-3 stronger alternative frames.

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Scenario 1

AI rollout moving faster than governance

Your company has piloted an internal AI assistant for drafting client emails, meeting summaries, and proposal outlines. Early feedback is positive: teams report saving time, adoption is spreading informally, and several senior leaders want to expand it quickly across sales, operations, and HR. However, Legal has raised concerns about confidential data being pasted into the tool. HR is worried managers may start using AI-generated summaries in performance discussions without context. The IT security lead says the pilot was never designed for enterprise-wide use. Meanwhile, a competitor has publicly announced a company-wide AI productivity rollout, and your CEO is asking why your company is moving slowly. You are on the executive team. A decision is needed within 2 weeks.

Known facts

- Pilot users report average time savings of 20–30% on routine drafting tasks.
- No known major incident has occurred yet.
- There are no finalized internal policies for acceptable AI use.
- The company handles sensitive client and employee information.
- Employee sentiment is mixed: enthusiasm from some teams, caution from others.
- The CEO wants a visible signal of progress this quarter.

Decision pressure
Do you scale now, pause, limit rollout, or redesign the rollout approach?

Worksheet prompts

Current frames Write 2–3 possible frames	**Dominant frame** The frame driving your instinctive response
_____ _____ _____	_____ Why it may be incomplete: 1. _____ 2. _____
Alternative better frames Generate 2–3 stronger options	**Winning frame + rewritten decision**
_____ _____ _____	Winning frame: _____ Rewritten decision question: _____ _____

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Scenario 2

Promotion choice or turnaround design?

A regional business unit is underperforming and needs a new leader. One candidate is a star executive with a strong record of delivering growth, moving fast, and making tough calls. Several board members support the promotion. However, internal feedback suggests this leader leaves behind strained teams, high attrition, and weak cross-functional relationships. In the last role, results improved sharply, but employee engagement scores fell and two senior people resigned. There has been no formal misconduct finding, but concerns are well known. The current business context is difficult: the unit needs a turnaround in the next 12 months, but morale is already fragile. The CEO wants a recommendation by the end of the week.

Known facts

- Candidate has exceeded revenue targets in 3 of the last 4 years.
- Previous team attrition was 22%, versus a company average of 11%.
- Employee survey comments describe the leader as “brilliant,” “demanding,” and “hard to trust.”
- No formal policy violation or ethical breach has been substantiated.
- The business unit needs both performance improvement and organizational stability.
- There is one internal alternative candidate with a stronger people reputation but less turnaround experience.

Decision pressure
Do you appoint the high performer, choose the steadier alternative, delay, split the role, or redesign the mandate?

Worksheet prompts

Current frames Write 2–3 possible frames	**Dominant frame** The frame driving your instinctive response
_____ _____ _____	_____ Why it may be incomplete: 1. _____ 2. _____
Alternative better frames Generate 2–3 stronger options	**Winning frame + rewritten decision**
_____ _____ _____	Winning frame: _____ Rewritten decision question: _____ _____

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Speed over depth

With AI, there is a bias now to move as quickly as possible without thoughtful and clear thinking. Who has time to read the full document when a summary has done the job, and there is no value in depth anymore when information can be easily accessed and summarized to my taste

Good-enough vs high-fidelity decisions

When 60-75% is good enough to move, AI reliance may be better. When nothing less than 90-95% is good enough to move, AI reliance is risky. What AI may solve for is the peripheral vision of decision making (optimize for speed, but not fidelity)

Rationality vs irrationality

How does AI affect human rationality and irrationality when making decisions? The tendency to ground all human rationales and thinking in 'rationality' often limits truly brave decisions as the tendency for AI is to avoid irrationality in all cases. But does irrationality in decisions always lead to good decisions?

Consequence and accountability

Lack of consequence limits good decisions. AI does not have to face consequences for real world decisions, and hence it is biased towards safety and generally risk aversive decisions

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